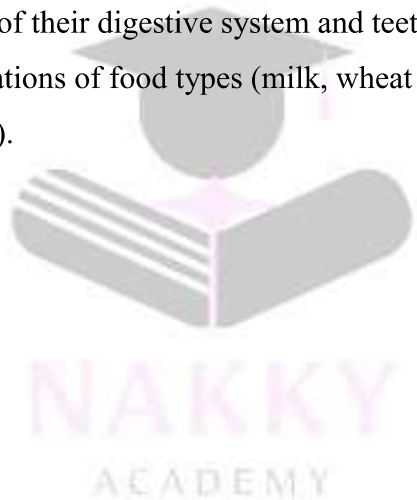


PROMOTING HEALTH NUTRITION AND EATING HABITS AMONG CHILDREN ACCORDING TO AGE

Healthy nutrition is important for their **emotional** and **cognitive growth**. Meals are also an important time for children to **interact with their caregivers** and to recognize that they are **loved** and **appreciated**. During family meals, children learn to become **members of the family**, and later of the **community**. Healthy eating habits (identifying and acquiring a taste for nutritious foods, eating at healthy intervals and in healthy doses) are also acquired in infancy. At the table, children learn by example. By observing their caregivers, they learn the habits of sharing, waiting for their turns, and using the cutlery and glassware – all important social skills.

Depending on the development of their digestive system and teeth formation, children accept different selections and combinations of food types (milk, wheat and cereals, meat) and consistency (liquid, soupy, hard).



HEALTHY NUTRITION FOR CHILDREN AND THE ROLE OF CAREGIVERS IN PROMOTING HEALTHY EATING HABITS (BY AGE CATEGORY)

AGE CATEGORY	MENU SELECTION & COMBINATION	PROMOTING HEALTHY EATING HABITS
Infants (0-6months)	The World Health Organization (WHO) and United Nations Children’s Fund (UNICEF) recommend exclusive breastfeeding for the first 6 months of an infant’s life, and introduction of nutritionally adequate and safe complementary (solid) foods at six months together with continued breastfeeding up to two years of age or beyond. At the sixth month, caregivers should supplement milk with other types of food, the consistency of which should be rather thick. Babies’ stomachs cannot hold a lot of food at a time, and liquid preparations have more water relative to nutrients. When infants enter into their seventh month, caregivers must feed them two to three meals a day. In addition	It is very important for the caregiver to maintain her calm and patience when feeding the infant. The caregiver must maintain eye contact with the infant as s/he eats. This is an important part of a child’s socialization process. The caregiver must add one food type at a time to the infant’s diet to test his/her tolerance levels to different food types. A caregiver should offer the same type of food over several days to allow the baby to adjust to its taste/flavor. At this age, children become more aware of the food that they are consuming. A caregiver should let them use their hands to learn about the different consistencies
7-8 Months		

	to the foods suggested earlier, caregivers can progressively add the following ingredients: noodles, rolled oats and barley; shredded vegetables (e.g., zucchini); hardboiled egg yolk added to purees and other preparations; well-cooked and sifted peas, lentils, chickpeas, beans, etc.	of food preparations. At this age, children need more nutritious foods than adults. It is therefore important that caregivers avoid soft drinks and concentrated bottled juices. Instead, caregivers must give them potable water or natural fruit juices with a teaspoon or in drinking cups.
Infants 9-12 Months	The WHO and UNICEF recommends frequent, on-demand breastfeeding until two years of age or beyond. Children at this age eat three or four meals a day (e.g., breakfast, lunch, afternoon snack and dinner). A caregiver can incorporate the following into their daily diet: • Carefully washed and peeled fresh fruits in small pieces. • Seedless and skinless tomato • pulp, beets and spinach, sweet potato or quince. • Grated or minced meat and fish (caregivers should remove all bones and thorns).	Vegetable oil should be added in small amounts to improve the taste of foods. While children are fond of sugar, it is recommended that caregivers use it in small quantities. Children must learn not to sweeten their meal to reduce the likelihood of developing diabetes as adults. It is advisable to combine meat and vegetables, pasta or rice in every meal. Avoid large chunks of food, sticky or seedy/thorny food types.

	- Well-cooked and chopped whole egg (two to three times a week) to replace meat. - Stuffed pasta and stews with very little seasoning.	
First Year	The WHO and UNICEF recommends frequent, on-demand breastfeeding until two years of age or beyond. At this age, children eat the same foods as the rest of the family. They also eat several meals throughout the day (e.g., breakfast, lunch, afternoon snack and dinner). Therefore, caregivers must avoid the following foods as they may contain harmful substances: - Cold cuts, hamburgers, sausages (contain fats, salt and preservatives). - Sauces, soups and broth that are prepared with cubes and instant soups (high in monosodium and salt). - Very spicy foods. - Weed tea (e.g., star anise, linden, chamomile, among others) might trigger allergies in children. - Soda, artificial juices, soy milk. - Salty and fatty products such as fried potatoes, cheese sticks. - Fried food every day.	At this stage, children would have developed opinions about certain types of food. Caregivers must be patient and serve food with affection and perseverance in spite of children's rejection and strong opinions. Caregivers must monitor children's food intake by staying with the child until it finishes eating. Children, when left alone, could spit the food. The variety of foods and their attractive appearance are stimuli that favor the attitude of the child towards food. Caregivers can make the food appealing by preparing combination of foods of different colors, sizes, textures and tastes. Children at this stage want to touch everything, including the food in their plates. Caregivers must not serve the food too warm. Also, caregivers must ensure children have washed their hands prior to eating and trim their nails to avoid dirt from stocking up underneath.

	• Do not use ready-made desserts. They may contain preservatives to prolong their shelf life. • Honey could contain spores that may cause botulism (poisoning) in the infant's intestines, and it is therefore recommended not to feed honey to the infants before the age of one year	The atmosphere at the table should be calm. It is therefore important to keep the TV off during meal times. Eating is an important social moment, one that contributes to the emotional growth of the child.
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